

QUICK BREADS ENCOMPASS LOAF BREADS LIKE banana bread, cornbread, and Irish soda bread as well as their diminutive counterparts: muffins, biscuits, and scones. Although these breads may differ in size and shape, they have a number of elements in common. All of these baked goods can be quickly prepared (the batter or dough can usually be assembled in the time it takes to preheat the oven) and quickly baked. This sets them far apart from yeast breads, which must rise for hours on the counter. All quick breads contain chemical leaveners (baking soda and baking powder) that are speedy and reliable.

There are several methods typically used to assemble quick breads. The most common, often referred to as the quick-bread method, calls for measuring wet and dry ingredients separately, pouring wet into dry, and then mixing them together as quickly as possible, usually with a wooden spoon or spatula. A second technique, often called the creaming method and more common to cake batters, starts with creaming the butter and sugar until light and fluffy—usually with an electric mixer. Eggs and flavorings are beaten in, then the dry and liquid ingredients are alternately added. A third possibility comes from the biscuit- and pie dough-making tradition, in which cold fat is cut into the dry ingredients with fingertips, forks, a pastry blender, or the blade of

a food processor. Once the mixture has achieved a cornmeal-like texture with pea-size flecks, the liquid is added and quickly mixed in.

In addition to mixing methods, it's also important to pay attention to the choice of flour and leaveners in these recipes. The protein content of the flour can greatly affect the texture of simple baked goods. To read more about flour, see page 733.

BANANA BREAD

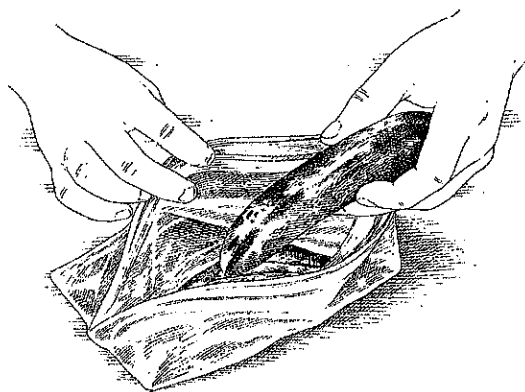
GOOD BANANA BREAD IS SOFT AND TENDER with plenty of banana flavor and crunchy toasted walnuts. It should be moist and light, something so delicious that you look forward to the bananas on the next bite, rather than turning soft and mushy. However, many banana breads are flat, gritty, or heavy. Worse, some taste only remotely of bananas.

In our testing, we found it very important to pay close attention to the condition of the bananas. Sweet, older, darkly speckled bananas infused the bread with both moisture and flavor, which helped that the bread, whether still warm or day-old, succeeded with less butter (minus 2 tablespoons) than the amount used in most recipes (½ cup).

We also experimented with the way we mashed the banana for the batter: slightly mashed, well mashed, and pureed. Loaves with slightly mashed bananas left chunks of fruit. We preferred a smoother texture, but pureeing the bananas turned out to be a bad idea, because the batter did not rise as well. Leavener probably escaped the thin batter developed enough structure to trap the gases. Bananas well mashed by hand kept the batter thick.

We wanted more moisture in the bread, so we tried mixing in milk, buttermilk, sour cream, and plain yogurt. Sour cream added richness to the bread, but it also made for a heavy texture and an unattractive, pebbly crust. Milk added moisture and flavor and created a slick crust. Buttermilk added a delightful tang, but yogurt let the banana flavor stand out. And because yogurt has more moisture than buttermilk, it made for a somewhat more solid loaf, which we preferred.

STORING OVERRIPE BANANAS FOR BANANA BREAD



Place overripe bananas in a zipper-lock plastic bag and freeze them. As available, add more bananas to the bag. When you are ready to make bread, thaw the bananas on the counter until softened.

While the added yogurt softened the bread's crumb, we still sought a more delicate, open grain. We decided to experiment with various mixing methods to see how they affected the final texture. We considered the quick-bread method (dry ingredients mixed in one bowl, liquids in another, with the two then gently stirred together) and the creaming method (butter and sugar creamed together, dry and wet ingredients then alternately mixed in).

The creaming method created a soft texture (reminiscent of butter cake) and good volume from the whipped sugar and butter. However, its lighter color looked less appetizing next to the golden brown loaf achieved with the quick-bread method. The quick-bread method produced a delicate texture, too, and the less consistent crumb looked hearty and delicious. It also rose more than the creamed loaf. All in all, it was a better choice.

Take caution when mixing, though. When we stirred the wet and the dry ingredients into a smooth batter, the loaves turned out small and tough. Flour contains protein, and when protein mixes with water, gluten develops. The more you stir with a spoon, the more the gluten proteins form into long, orderly bundles. These bundles create an elastic batter that resists changing shape and cannot rise as well. To minimize gluten development, fold together the wet and dry ingredients gently, just until the dry ingredients are moistened. The batter should still be thick and chunky, but without any streaks of unincorporated flour.

Banana Bread

MAKES ONE 9-INCH LOAF

For best results, be sure to use a loaf pan that measures 9 inches long, 5 inches across, and 3 inches deep.

- 2 cups (10 ounces) unbleached all-purpose flour, plus more for dusting the pan
- 1 1/4 cups walnuts, chopped coarse
- 3/4 cup (5 1/4 ounces) sugar
- 3/4 teaspoon baking soda
- 1/2 teaspoon salt
- 4 X very ripe, soft, darkly speckled large bananas, mashed well (about 1 1/2 cups)
- 1/4 cup plain yogurt
- 2 large eggs, beaten lightly
- 6 tablespoons (3/4 stick) unsalted butter, melted and cooled
- 1 teaspoon vanilla extract

1. Adjust an oven rack to the lower-middle position and heat the oven to 350 degrees. Grease the bottom and sides of a 9 by 5-inch loaf pan; dust with flour, tapping out the excess.

2. Spread the walnuts on a baking sheet and toast until fragrant, 5 to 10 minutes. Set aside to cool.

3. Whisk the flour, sugar, baking soda, salt, and walnuts together in a large bowl; set aside.

4. Mix the mashed bananas, yogurt, eggs, butter, and vanilla with a wooden spoon in a medium bowl. Lightly fold the banana mixture into the

EQUIPMENT: Loaf Pans

A good loaf pan will evenly brown banana bread and other quick breads (as well as yeast breads, such as sandwich bread and cakes like pound cake). In addition, loaves should release cleanly and pans should be easy to get in and out of the oven, with little chance of sticking an oven mitt into the batter or baked bread.

We tested 10 loaf pans made from a variety of materials, including metal, glass, and stoneware. We found that dark-colored metal loaf pans browned breads more evenly than light-colored metal pans. Most of the dark metal pans were lined with a nonstick coating that also made the release of baked breads especially easy. We found that sweet breads, such as banana bread, were especially prone to burning in glass loaf

pans. Sticking was also a problem in these pans. Stoneware loaf pans did a decent job of browning, but we had trouble removing loaves from these pans. Our testers found that pans with handles at either end were easier to work with and kept us from sticking an oven mitt into the edge of a baked loaf.

In the end, we recommend that you buy metal loaf pans with a nonstick coating. Although there's no harm in spending more money on heavier pans, the cheapest, lightest pan in our testing (Ecko Baker's Secret, \$4) was the favorite. One final piece of advice: Even with the nonstick coating, we recommend greasing and flouring your loaf pan to ensure easy release. Nothing is worse than losing a quick bread to the pan.

dry ingredients with a rubber spatula until just combined and the batter looks thick and chunky. Scrape the batter into the prepared loaf pan.

5. Bake until the loaf is golden brown and a toothpick inserted in the center comes out clean, about 55 minutes. Cool in the pan for 5 minutes, then transfer to a wire rack. Serve warm or at room temperature. (The bread can be wrapped with plastic wrap and stored at room temperature for up to 3 days.)

➤ VARIATIONS

Banana-Chocolate Bread

Follow the recipe for Banana Bread, reducing the sugar to 10 tablespoons and mixing 2½ ounces bittersweet chocolate, grated (a heaping ½ cup), into the dry ingredients.

Banana-Coconut Bread with Macadamia Nuts

Adjust an oven rack to the middle position and heat the oven to 350 degrees. Spread ½ cup sweetened flaked coconut and 1 cup chopped macadamia nuts on a baking sheet and toast, stirring every 2 minutes, until golden brown, about 6 minutes. Follow the recipe for Banana Bread, substituting the cooled toasted macadamias and coconut for the walnuts.

Orange-Spice Banana Bread

Follow the recipe for Banana Bread, adding 1 teaspoon ground cinnamon, ¼ teaspoon freshly grated nutmeg, and 2 tablespoons grated orange zest to the dry ingredients.

CRANBERRY-NUT BREAD

TOO OFTEN, THIS SIMPLE QUICK BREAD IS SUBPAR, sunken in the middle, too dense, or so overly sweetened that the contrast between the tart berries and what should be a slightly sweet dough is lost. We wanted to avoid these problems, and we had some other goals in mind as well. We were looking for a crust that was golden brown and evenly thin all the way around and a texture that was somewhere between a dense breakfast bread

and a light, airy cake. After looking at almost 60 recipes, it seemed evident that the mixing method and the leavening were the most important factors in getting the quick bread we were after.

First we tackled mixing. Some recipes called for the creaming method, others the quick-bread method. We made several loaves using each of these methods. While the creaming method did give us a marginally more tender bread, we quickly determined that it was too light and airy. We liked the denser, more compact texture produced by the quick-bread method.

Next we moved on to leavening. When we looked back at our testing, we noted that 75 percent of the recipes combined baking powder with baking soda to leaven the bread. The rest used baking powder or all baking soda. We tried every option we could think of using these two leaveners, both alone and together. We found that baking powder seemed to enhance the flavor, while baking soda supported the structure; finding the right balance was tricky. Eventually, we came to the decision that ¼ teaspoon of baking soda combined with 1 teaspoon of baking powder gave us the bright flavor and rich texture we were looking for.

With our mixing and leavening methods settled, we focused on ingredients. We quickly determined that we liked the flavor that butter provided over that of oil, margarine, or shortening. More than one egg made the bread almost too rich and caused the interior to turn somewhat yellow. After testing different amounts and types of sugar, we stuck with 1 cup of granulated sugar, which provided just the right amount of sweetness. Orange zest provided a nice complement to the tart cranberries.

We also tinkered with the liquid component. Many recipes called for water or even boiling water, but freshly squeezed orange juice was usually mentioned and offered the best flavor.

Not every recipe called for dairy, but we tested everything from heavy cream to sour cream. Both buttermilk and yogurt provided the moistness and tang we were looking for, with buttermilk edging out yogurt by a hairbreadth.

Last but not least were the cranberries. The cranberry harvest begins just after Labor Day and continues through early fall, which means that